Diwali, the Festival of Lights, Is Today

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Diwali is the biggest festival of the year in India, and it falls today, November 8. More than one billion people celebrate it, in India and around the world. Its name comes from '**Deepavali**,' which means 'a row of lights.' People put rows of small **clay** oil lamps outside their homes. The lights stand for good winning over evil, and learning over not knowing. Diwali follows the Hindu **moon calendar**, so it usually falls in late October or early November. **Hindus**, Sikhs, Jains, and Buddhists all mark the day. In southern India, people celebrate Lord Krishna's win over the **demon** Naraka. In northern India, they celebrate Lord Rama coming home with his wife, Sita, and his brother, Lakshmana, after 14 years in the forest. Families light lamps and fireworks, eat big meals, wear new clothes, and pray. Some people buy gold on **Dhanteras**, the first day of the festival, for good luck. In North America, Disney World in Florida had events with more than 500 dancers, and New York City marked its 11th year of Diwali at Times Square.

Word Treasure

Deepavali -- It is the older name for Diwali, and it means 'a row of lights'.
demon -- A demon is a bad spirit or monster in a story.
Dhanteras -- The first day of the Diwali festival, when some people buy gold for good luck.
clay -- Clay is a soft earth that can be shaped and baked hard to make lamps and pots.
Hindus -- Hindus are people who follow Hinduism, one of the faiths that celebrate Diwali.
moon calendar -- A moon calendar is a way of setting dates by the phases of the moon.

Background you need

Diwali is a festival of lights celebrated by Hindus, Sikhs, Jains, and Buddhists.

Families light small oil lamps to show good winning over evil and learning winning over not knowing.

Different places tell different stories for the day, such as Lord Krishna's win over the demon Naraka in the south and Lord Rama's return home in the north.

Break it down

WHO: More than one billion Hindus, Sikhs, Jains, and Buddhists in India and around the world
WHAT: Diwali, the festival of lights, with lamps, fireworks, meals, new clothes, and prayer
WHERE: In India and around the world, including Disney World in Florida and Times Square in New York City
WHY: To celebrate good winning over evil and learning winning over not knowing

Why it matters

Diwali shows you how families in your class or neighborhood may celebrate light, kindness, and learning with lamps and big meals.

Test what you remember

1. What does the name Diwali come from?

- (A) Dhanteras
- (B) Naraka
- (C) Times Square
- (D) Deepavali

2. What do the lights of Diwali stand for?

- (A) People moving to a new home
- (B) Winter coming
- (C) Good winning over evil
- (D) A new year starting

3. In southern India, whose win do people celebrate at Diwali?

- (A) Lord Krishna's birthday
- (B) Lord Rama's wedding
- (C) Lord Rama's return home
- (D) Lord Krishna's win over the demon Naraka

4. In northern India, who came home after 14 years in the forest?

- (A) Sita's brother
- (B) Lord Rama
- (C) Lord Krishna
- (D) Naraka

5. How many dancers took part in the Disney World events in Florida?

- (A) Exactly 50
- (B) More than 5,000
- (C) More than 500
- (D) About 100

6. What do some people buy on Dhanteras for good luck?

- (A) Gold
- (B) New clothes
- (C) Fireworks
- (D) Clay lamps

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: D 4: B 5: C 6: A

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):